



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 49

WISCONSIN

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Wisconsin's family courts and child-welfare system.

47

WISCONSIN FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
89 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 24 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 10, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

25 OF 72

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WISCONSIN AT A GLANCE.

Across 47 Wisconsin families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 89 47 of 47 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$68,000 median across 31 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 24 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 63.8% 40.4% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 47	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.9	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 47 of 47	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 25

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Wisconsin families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF WISCONSIN FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	32	\$20,000	\$44,105	\$1,411,350
Lost Wages	32	\$12,500	\$34,414	\$1,101,260
Other Court Fees	19	\$5,000	\$12,458	\$236,700
Therapy / Evaluations	24	\$3,000	\$10,356	\$248,550
Reunification Services	13	\$100	\$2,469	\$32,100
GAL Fees	31	\$4,800	\$8,474	\$262,700
Asset Loss	23	\$65,000	\$127,362	\$2,929,324
Median Family Burden (31 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$68,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		24	2 yrs
Mean months lost		37	3.1 yrs
Total across all families		1,207	100.6 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · WISCONSIN

Most families documenting in Wisconsin are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		25	53%
Not provided		10	21%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		6	13%
Active case: progress being made		4	9%
Not in court but still affected		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only		19	40%
Both Family Court and CPS		19	40%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		6	13%
Unknown		3	6%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		13	28%
5 – 10 years		13	28%
6 months – 1 year		6	13%
Over 10 years		5	11%
3 – 5 years		4	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		14	30%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		13	28%
50/50 Joint		9	19%
Children in Foster Care		6	13%
Full Custody		3	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Dane		6	13%
Waukesha		3	6%
Brown		2	4%
Rock		2	4%
Milwaukee		2	4%
Racine		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		15	32%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		11	23%
High Conflict Divorce		4	9%
Other		3	6%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		3	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — WISCONSIN

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Wisconsin comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



This system with CPS has destroyed my heart. The relationship with my children is severed and it feels so heavy on my heart I think about them everyday and all I want to do is hug them.

— JAMIE

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The system to protect my family, ripped us apart, chewed us up, charged me to earn my rights back to even talk to my son-at the cost of our family home. We were never provided a fair trial or any legal steps to make this make sense. No due process, did not allow the "experts" [...]

— WISCONSIN PARENT · DANIELLE

MORE VOICES FROM WISCONSIN

Destroyed my family and traumatized 2 toddler girls in a way I experienced as a kid and NEVER wanted them to suffer.

— ALYSSA

Lengthened the process, falsely accused me the mom and victim of domestic violence of parents alienation, kids are terrified, kids have NO voice, daughter Noe has mental health issues and diagnosis of OCD and is begging for her voice to be heard in court. I am losing my home [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Failed my children and I. We cannot count on any protection in the hands of the system. The system is the Devil. Lost trust within the system. They have traumatized us beyond the trauma we already had with the family abuse.

— CRYSTAL

Taken my civil rights to parent and be in my children's daily life. Ignored the true abuse to the children, by allowing convercive control through parent alienation of a targeted parent.

— JOY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I was made to pay to give my children away to my abuser including my daughter who is not biologically his. I was threatened with 6 months of jail time if I didn't pay GAL fees all while still having no access to my children and trying to rebuild my life.

— CHANDI

The system came into our lives and destroyed everything with a wrecking ball. My child has suffered extensive abuse and trauma, and now suffers from PTSD.

— MICHELLE

Family court has left me and my children feeling unsafe, mistreated with manipulation and gaslighting. The system has only allowed my ex to hide behind it, continue his abuse and use his lawyer to bully me and continue to use cohesive control. The system is corrupt, dark and not [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They denied me due process, stripped me of my business, investment properties, and all income, denied maintenance, and ignored documented attorney abuse, resulting in over \$700,000 in losses, forced reliance on public assistance, homelessness, and the destruction of my family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family, injured my kids and caused them more harm - it will take them decades to understand what happened and to heal.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

After years of (well documented) domestic abuse and coercive control, my abuser has been rewarded for the harm he caused. I have no home, no transportation, no stability whatsoever, a lien on any future income, tens of thousands of dollars in debt, and severe chronic PTSD. I've [...]

— KIRA

It has given both my daughter and I trauma. We no longer trust anyone to actually help us who is supposed to help.

— DAWN

The system has destroyed my family.

— ROBERT

My daughter was ripped away from me and I have been forced to relive the traumas of the past over and over. They have cause great harm in my daughters development.

— CORTNEE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I lost my kiddo for protecting her against the abuse and neglect from her father and family

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have tore my family apart and caused many hours of pain and suffering for not only myself but my child, my other 3 kids, and her father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I do not see my kids though they are adults now. My daughter is a narcissist, devil worshiper. My son has finally realized how messed up the court system is. I pray for them both.

— APRIL

This system forced the liquidation of assets and belongings, purchased with disability income, imposed restraining orders without evidence, involved law enforcement, enabled ongoing harassment, silenced my autistic son, confiscated his phone after he attempted to escape by [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex was convicted of second degree sexual assault of a child. My daughter was the victim. He threatened to kills us. I was granted a 10 year DVPO and he was sentenced to 4 years in prison, 6 years extended supervision, and is a lifelong registered sex offender. My two young [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have watched my children deteriorate physically and psychologically. I have experienced the death of hope, the loss of the mother i wanted to be, the life I worked for stolen, the relationship I had with my children sabotaged.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has trafficked my 3 beautiful daughters out of my safe home and into their perpetrators home full-time. They have lied over and over and ripped me apart in every way imaginable to fit their false narratives.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken me from being a daily mother to allowing the father to push me out of my kid's lives entirely.

— SAMANTHA

Put my child and myself in danger, no help or protection, gave my child to the abuser. Left me broken, shattered, and facing criminal charges based on made up stories.

— HOLLY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



In my experience the system frowns upon any type of abuse besides directly physical being brought up, does not give victims the right to speak, and it brings children into dangerous situations. It allows for predators to take advantage of “court-rulings” and to gain power over [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The unwillingness of the system actors to investigate, draw sound conclusions, and act in the best interests of the children is disgusting. The collusion to increase billing hours is horrible.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

These monsters stole my babies and sold their childhood for their own profits. I’ll never get those moments back... they stole my life when they stole my kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I’ve lost huge amounts of time of a loving daughter, from interference as well as alienation. College educations for my kids were paid to lawyers for years of conflict generated for the sake of additional litigation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Unfairly judged. I told the judge about how my children are not dressed or fed well and that court should care about their well being but he chuckled at me and ignored me. I told the court that I lived in a different state at the time of divorce and he still ignored his out of [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

every negative thing you could think about. and all for revenge.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

* Loss of physical custody * Chronic stress from ongoing court supervision * substantial Financial strain from required services, travel, and legal costs * Severe Emotional distress tied to uncertainty and separation * Completely Reduced autonomy in parenting decisions due to [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Loss of time and memories!

— AMANDA

The system has broken my child because they believe 50/50 is what is just for the parents but refuse to acknowledge the ramifications of what that does to the child. The system is failing children and forcing them to be in situations their parent left. I have cared for my [...]

— AMANDA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Everyone I've met and dealt with through this case that works with CPS has told me over and over how good of a father I am but yet I sit here without tucking my daughter into bed every night. My daughter had a diaper rash for 4 months straight after they removed her from me for [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system totally screwed up the family all I was doing was what was in her best interest I always looked at what was in her best interest and it looks like the g a l the case worker the social worker that was for my daughter did what was in Ryan's best interest who is the [...]

— VICKI

Remove the child from their primary parents based off of allegations and no justified due process time as an emergency expert order is supposed to be temporary and it has been in place now almost 4 months pushing it towards almost being the new standard placement

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Based on unverified allegations, I was separated from my children, leading to devastating consequences including my son's mental decline and PTSD diagnosis, another child developing severe anxiety, and the loss of our relationship, while I have been left financially unstable [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has put my son in the custody of a documented physically and emotional abusive parent with no supervision or monitoring. The system tore my sons mother from his life, the only constant and safe parenting he had known since birth 2013. The system im referring to here [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

38 Wisconsin parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 38 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — WISCONSIN

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Wisconsin families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The system to protect my family, ripped us apart, chewed us up, charged me to earn my rights back to even talk to my son- at the cost of our family home. We were never provided a fair trial or any legal steps to make this make sense. No due process, did not allow the "experts" to be deposed. As a result, the 457 days my son was ripped away from his "safe" parent and family- his brother and grandmother as well- CPS then placed him right back at home with me. However, now that my son is home I have FULL PLACEMENT and NO CUSTODY. Can't make this up. I am a teacher. I work with kids my son's age everyday. What the courts are doing NEEDS URGENT REFORM. Thank you SO much Megan for your voice. I get through many of my days because of you. I am more than willing to be involved to get the word out there and expose each and every one.

— DANIELLE

This system with CPS has destroyed my heart. The relationship with my children is severed and it feels so heavy on my heart I think about them everyday and all I want to do is hug them.

— JAMIE

Destroyed my family and traumatized 2 toddler girls in a way I experienced as a kid and NEVER wanted them to suffer.

— ALYSSA

Lengthened the process, falsely accused me the mom and victim of domestic violence of parents alienation, kids are terrified, kids have NO voice, daughter Noe has mental health issues and diagnosis of OCD and is begging for her voice to be heard in court. I am losing my home because I can't afford to keep fighting my x. He makes half a million a year and has 4 attorneys, he files false allegations and I get drained financially fighting him. Our kids are slowly dying inside every time they have to be with him and be abused by him. No one will listen to the kids. Their doctors have called the police and cps and crickets.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Failed my children and I. We cannot count on any protection in the hands of the system. The system is the Devil. Lost trust within the system. They have traumatized us beyond the trauma we already had with the family abuse.

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— CHANDI

The system came into our lives and destroyed everything with a wrecking ball. My child has suffered extensive abuse and trauma, and now suffers from PTSD.

— MICHELLE

Family court has left me and my children feeling unsafe, mistreated with manipulation and gaslighting. The system has only allowed my ex to hide behind it, continue his abuse and use his lawyer to bully me and continue to use cohesive control. The system is corrupt, dark and not operating to protect people, and honor our God given constitutional rights. The PTSD has left me in fear of even looking for another lawyer.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They denied me due process, stripped me of my business, investment properties, and all income, denied maintenance, and ignored documented attorney abuse, resulting in over \$700,000 in losses, forced reliance on public assistance, homelessness, and the destruction of my family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family, injured my kids and caused them more harm - it will take them decades to understand what happened and to heal.

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

After years of (well documented) domestic abuse and coercive control, my abuser has been rewarded for the harm he caused. I have no home, no transportation, no stability whatsoever, a lien on any future income, tens of thousands of dollars in debt, and severe chronic PTSD. I've been pillaged to the point where I have literally nothing left to give; so now they're trying to throw me in jail to shut me up. My money, children, and reputation weren't enough, now they're trying to steal my life force and will to live. Family court is a system of legalized torture and slavery for profit.

— KIRA

It has given both my daughter and I trauma. We no longer trust anyone to actually help us who is supposed to help.

— DAWN

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— ROBERT

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— APRIL

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

This system forced the liquidation of assets and belongings, purchased with disability income, imposed restraining orders without evidence, involved law enforcement, enabled ongoing harassment, silenced my autistic son, confiscated his phone after he attempted to escape by dialing 911, caused severe trauma and mental health damages requiring significant therapy and ultimately jailed me for falling apart, tearing my family apart and stripping me and my son of our rights.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex was convicted of second degree sexual assault of a child. My daughter was the victim. He threatened to kills us. I was granted a 10 year DVPO and he was sentenced to 4 years in prison, 6 years extended supervision, and is a lifelong registered sex offender. My two young sons who were 18 months at 4 years at the time of his arrest were ordered by the family court to be driven to the prison by complete strangers (men from a jail prayer ministry) to visit him. Immediately upon his release from prison he was awarded weekly 4 hour visits with the same church men supervising. Despite my boys now being 8 and 11 and having fulfilled lives and relationships. He continues to file motion after motion after motion which is a form of post separation abuse as a means to financially harm me. The criminal court advocated for me and my kids and I felt hope that we would be protected. Unfortunately in family court all they care about is his right to “meaningful and reoccurring placement” instead of the boys’ rights to be safe.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Put my child and myself in danger, no help or protection, gave my child to the abuser. Left me broken, shattered, and facing criminal charges based on made up stories.

— HOLLY

In my experience the system frowns upon any type of abuse besides directly physical being brought up, does not give victims the right to speak, and it brings children into dangerous situations. It allows for predators to take advantage of “court-rulings” and to gain power over their victims further. Context should be read in before every case, but this is seldom taken into account. For situations that include financial abuse, religious abuse, emotional torment, sexual abuse but not rape, and misogynistic relationships that involve a rather “controlling” and “intimidating” in nature, it seems as though nobody gives a rats ass. The system is built off of “documentation” but why should we wait for terrible things to happen for them to be proven to the court? At the expense of our childrens safety?! Why shouldn’t mothers who were victims of ANY type of abuse be heard- even if those types of abuse are COMMON to a “human being” but not COMMON in family court? If false allegations just keep getting dismissed, does that mean that either party can just start throwing them around willy nilly? No. This is not justice.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The unwillingness of the system actors to investigate, draw sound conclusions, and act in the best interests of the children is disgusting. The collusion to increase billing hours is horrible.

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Unfairly judged. I told the judge about how my children are not dressed or fed well and that court should care about their well being but he chuckled at me and ignored me. I told the court that I lived in a different state at the time of divorce and he still ignored his out of jurisdiction orders and my duo process completely issuing me to pay \$3000 a month specially when i got married again and now have two babies that need more support than my teen daughters with my ex.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

every negative thing you could think about. and all for revenge.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

* Loss of physical custody * Chronic stress from ongoing court supervision * substantial Financial strain from required services, travel, and legal costs * Severe Emotional distress tied to uncertainty and separation * Completely Reduced autonomy in parenting decisions due to court mandates * Risk of long-term loss of parental rights by a court without jurisdiction

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Loss of time and memories!

— AMANDA

The system has broken my child because they believe 50/50 is what is just for the parents but refuse to acknowledge the ramifications of what that does to the child. The system is failing children and forcing them to be in situations their parent left. I have cared for my daughter 24/7 for 2,200+ days without the help from my ex husband and now she is being forced to go with her father and its causing her regression, baby talk, thumb sucking, separation anxiety, depression, school issues, refusing to sleep, night terrors, etc.

— AMANDA

Everyone I've met and dealt with through this case that works with CPS has told me over and over how good of a father I am but yet I sit here without tucking my daughter into bed every night. My daughter had a diaper rash for 4 months straight after they removed her from me for breaking a policy they had for me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

This system totally screwed up the family all I was doing was what was in her best interest I always looked at what was in her best interest and it looks like the gal the case worker the social worker that was for my daughter did what was in Ryan's best interest who is the father they cost me so much money and so much depression I almost shot myself in the head I had my daughter and raised her by myself for six and a half years without any of their help. Friendships were strained family ties broken my daughter doesn't even remember half the people on my side she lost connections to her brother and other people that we knew she was torn away from organizations that she was part of and nobody even cared so this just didn't hurt me it hurt my daughter too. Especially after they first had her during the first 6 weeks they had her they wouldn't let her talk to me they wouldn't let her see me and she fell and they didn't tell me about it it was her teacher that told me about it during her conferences and what changed is when they finally allowed me to see her and then they caused even more drama by having me supervised a paid supervisor to watch us sit and play for 4 hours that's \$200 an hour at twice a month that's \$1,600 a month and that went on for a year and a half that entire family is nothing but a narcissistic sociopathic psychotic piece of garbage.

— VICKI

Remove the child from their primary parents based off of allegations and no justified due process time as an emergency expert order is supposed to be temporary and it has been in place now almost 4 months pushing it towards almost being the new standard placement

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Based on unverified allegations, I was separated from my children, leading to devastating consequences including my son's mental decline and PTSD diagnosis, another child developing severe anxiety, and the loss of our relationship, while I have been left financially unstable, lost my employment, and cannot afford medical care for my heart condition as well as dealing with on going police harassment now under DOJ review (ex husband is a local detective.)

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has put my son in the custody of a documented physically and emotional abusive parent with no supervision or monitoring. The system tore my sons mother from his life, the only constant and safe parenting he had known since birth 2013. The system im referring to here is CPS and the family court.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

38 full approved Wisconsin comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Wisconsin report comes from Wisconsin respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Wisconsin — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 47 Wisconsin families reporting here are not the universe of Wisconsin families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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